

**UNRAVELLING THE MYSTICAL WORLD OF THE NAGAS
THROUGH THE FUSION OF UNIVERSAL WISDOM AND
SUPERNATURAL ELEMENTS IN KIRE'S *WHEN THE RIVER SLEEPS*
AND *SON OF THE THUNDERCLOUD***

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Abstract:

Easterine Kire as a poet, novelist, a short story writer and author of children books emerges as one of the most prolific writers from Northeast India who preserves, revives, celebrates and recreates the Naga tradition through her creations. The Nagas, inhabiting North East of India, belong to the Mongolian race of the Indo- Mongoloid group of the Tibeto Burman branch of Sino Tibetan family. A state which is relatively an unexplored, tribal region is home to sixteen tribes, which have their own distinct languages, social customs, traditions, beliefs and practices. The lives of the Nagas evolve around the tribes, villages, family, and clan. The tribes have their own dialect so each tribe communicates through Nagamese Creole and English. The people are self-sufficient, as their lives are based on the agricultural cycle. The Nagas always considered their land as an independent nation and every Naga village as an independent republic since no tribe has dominated or ruled over the other. Kire makes an attempt to celebrate their uniqueness in her novels. *When the River Sleeps* and *Son of Thundercloud* resolves the Naga culture, their dreams, expectations and their troubles through the fusion of universal wisdom and the spiritual world. This paper portrays Kire as a modern ambassador and a guardian angel, who urges to protect her culture and the righteousness of the human beings. Standing in the crux of this situation modernization and globalization have laid the strong impact on leaning towards western culture. Nagaland has also become a victim of western cultural harmony. This paper reveals how Kire is safe-guarding their culture and guiding ignorant young Naga generation to realize their own rich heritage of culture and tradition.

Keywords: Folklore, Myth, Culture, Supernatural, Universal Wisdom, Identity, Human nature.

The seven sister states is a popular term for the contiguous states of Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Meghalaya, Manipur, Mizoram, Nagaland, Tripura and Sikkim into the Northeastern region of India. Nagaland was formed on December 1st, 1963. The literature of Nagaland is amalgamated with their cultural spirit and antiquated customs. Due to the lack of written evidence, Nagas get to know about their history, culture and identity through the folklore and myth. In Naga community there are different tribes and they believe in different myths of origin- the origin of tiger spirit, and the origin of stone or the myth of stone slabs. Naga minds are prepared to accept the co- existence of the natural and spiritual world. Naga people believe

life after death exists with Sprits, thus myths and folklores are part and parcel of the Naga culture. Culture can refer to the beliefs, customs, values and activities of a particular group of people at a particular time. Object produced by a given culture expresses these values in both overt and unconscious ways. In the same way Kire works both consciously and subconsciously expressing the values of Naga people. Naga people have enormous value in displaying a fusion of imagination, power and knowledge. Folk tales educate and entertain the people of Naga community. Nagas, practiced animism as their religion before the British colonization and they believed the nature has a divine power and spiritual essence to every element of nature. Thus Nagas believe in abode of supernatural powers. They worship kepenuophe as a birth spirit; rutzeh; telepfu; tsuke as sub- deities, the sub deities have originated from kepenuopfu, the birth spirit. It is believed that each of the spirit has spiritual ability; rutzeh, telepfu are responsible for driving out the evil happenings and several rituals are practiced to please those deities.

Easterine Kire Iralu is a Naga writer who belongs to Indo-Mongoloid tribe. She often vocals on historical and cultural issues confronting Naga society, and her fictional works act as the realistic representation of those issues. In one of her interviews, she remarks: "...the telling of individual stories is so important to the teller. It is a part of his or her healing and particularly amongst my people who have stories of deep pain and also wonder". ("Kire in the Hindu" www.TheHindu.com/.../Easterine-Kire/artic...) Easterine was honored with the Governor's medal for excellence in Naga literature (2011) and with the Catalan PEN international voice Award in Spain.

A Naga Village Remembered is Kire's first novel. It talks about the socio- cultural rituals and heroic performance of a warrior village. *A Terrible Matriarchy* is a bildungsroman which depicts the growth, emotions and experience of a female child. The novel uncovers the perplexed tribal identity through the story of Pielieno. *A Bitter Wormwood* unravels intense sufferings during freedom fight. Many poems are translated by Kire from native language to English and the character sketch of each novel is a classical epitome of a Naga people.

When the River Sleeps (2014) is a fusion mystical story of tribal identity, rituals, beliefs and their love towards land and their closed community. It has won The Hindu prize in 2014, *Son of the Thundercloud* (2016) is a story of a sojourner Pele, a man who lost his family in a famine and his aimless journey tracks him to ancient village and there he witnesses many surprises. The journey of protagonists of these two novels, Vilie and Pele unfolds the cultural beliefs and rituals of a Naga community through spiritual nature of Nagaland.

When the River sleeps (2014) unravels the journey of a hunter Vilie, who aspires to have a stone from a magical river and on his way he explores the wild and mystic forest in Nagaland. During the journey he was attacked by tiger and spirits. In Naga society spirits, forest deities and nature play predominant role and being constructed with an ancient iconic myth. At last Vilie acquires heart stone and returns to his village with Kirhupfimia woman Ate. Vilie, though he disappeared for several years, Ate still feels the presence of Vilie and feels that the heart stone is in the safest hands. Kire concludes the novel with Sanguine note that Naga culture will be preserved by the future generation- the little boy Vibou, the unborn child of Ate.

Son of the Thundercloud by Easterine Kire depicts the Pele's Journey through Nagaland, and the Journey results in the appreciation of the Naga culture along with the myths and the Supernatural elements. Pele, after losing all his family in a terrible famine, leaves his village and begins an aimless Journey. The Journey led him to the ancient women in an abandoned village called Nouné and his life changes after meeting them. They were waiting for rain about four hundred years and the single drop of rain would impregnate tiger widow and her son. Rhalie will fulfil his purpose of life by killing the tiger and unshackling humanity from the evil. Mesanuo will attain eternity and finally at the end Pele will realise the importance of a Naga culture and begins new journey to explore another fact of Nagaland.

Kire's novels *When the River Sleeps* and *Son of the Thundercloud* reveal the delusional world of Nagas which is intertwined with the universal wisdom. Naga culture with its rich oral tradition and folklore is divulged through Kire's novel and the novels consist of spirits, folklore, myths at its height. Universal wisdom is resumed through an enigmatic world.

“In general a Myth is a story which is not true and which involves (as a rule) supernatural beings – or at any rate supra-human beings. Myth is always concerned with creation. Myth explains how something came to exist. Myth embodies feeling and concept...” (Cuddon 526) Charles Chaise who has contributed extensively through his writings for political history and the evolution of Nagaland, finds it unfortunate that all Naga tribes have their history not in written form but have handed down through generations by the legends, folklore and oral traditions. In the oral narratives of Nagas folklore and myths are embedded the moral values and cultural values of the community. In her novel *Son of the Thundercloud*, Mesanuo, a tiger widow was impregnated by a single drop of rain, just as Dzilimossiro in the myth. In the novel *When the River Sleeps*, the heart stone from the mystic river is presented as a myth of Longterok which explains the Ao-Nagas consideration of six stones.

Supernatural story refers to a “very comprehensive term which may be applied to any sort of story which in some way makes use of ghosts, ghouls, spectres, apparitions, poltergeists, good and evil spirits... the eerie atmosphere and the presence of the uncanny; anything supra-normal and beyond sensory perception; what makes the flesh creep and the hair stand on end” (Cuddon 879-878). Nagaland is a hilly mountain area and a green lush landscape with mystic and supernatural elements in her novels. The natural world of Naga is suspicioned to have mystical beings. It is believed that the spirits are residing in rivers, flowers, forest, trees and stone. The natural world of the Naga is considered to be an abode of the mystical beings and elements. Mechuseno, a girl who is very gentle, lovable and kind-hearted who plucked a flower from forest and had it in her head. While returning home back she was accompanied by a spirit and after few days she passed away. The mysterious and malefic effect of the spirit mirrors the supernatural world of Nagas. Rarhuriais an unclean forest and it is considered as an abode of diverse spirits, which attracts children to play with them and they attract adults by singing melodic songs. The two ancient sisters from the abandoned village, Siedze and Kethonuo transform into spirits, and their body gradually start to disappear and they are transformed into

spirits in Kire's novel *Son of the Thundercloud*. Thus Kire's novels, like Naga culture merge the human, natural and supernatural world.

The novel, *When the River Sleeps* talks about the girl from village Kirhupfimia, Ate. Her soul was transformed with the help of a heart stone, though she belonged to a sinful village. She was cleansed and had a normal life. In *Son of Thundercloud*, as said by Kethonuo, Rhalietuo will defeat the tiger though he was very young, he could easily handle were-tiger. This affirms that the abysmal power of supernatural thwarts the temporal aspects in mankind and can be fathomed with a power of human soul.

In modern era the younger generations of Nagaland forsake their culture and traditions. The characters in Kire's novels function as a bridge to bind the supernatural knowledge of Naga world, along with its omnipresent sagacity. Thus the writer's obligation of preserving the Naga culture was accomplished by the characters such as Kani, old man, Mesanuo, Kethunou and Siedze.

The old man, without any prior knowledge identifies the heart stone with vilie and he imparts him with the knowledge of supernatural elements in Naga world. Old man explains how heart stone remains unattractive for the non-believers. Thus with the help of old man's character Kire unfolds the relevance of acceptance of the supernatural world to realize the true essence of Naga culture. Old man's guidance helped vilie throughout his journey and he helped vilie to identify the spirits that would delude the human beings in the form of river spirits.

Kire picturizes is the village of Kirhupfimia and confines the faith of Naga people in supernatural elements. Ate belongs to Kirhupfimia, a village with the women members who possess the evil spirits at the tip of their fingers and so they are isolated and live in a separate village. Even though they were isolated from the normal world, few people from the village used to enquire the remedial acts for curing the disease which was not cured for many months by the normal people. And they used to suggest few herbs to cure the problems. When logical ways fail to solve they depend on the other forms. The supernatural powers and the vast knowledge of Naga people are interlined. The character of Ate renders the readers with the understanding of Naga culture with supernatural elements and universal wisdom at the substratum. Ate explains the true purpose of the stone to Vilie. "The heart stone is also a stumbling stone and people who don't understand its mysteries can possess it but also stumble and lose their way (142) therefore the lack of faith or disbelief in the supernatural world of Nagas and their imitations of western and other cultures are gradually eradicating their tradition and culture making them anonymous (Thong 56) and thus human world depends on supernatural element and ideas at times. Through Ate, Kire unveils that the dependency of the supernatural element is common in Naga culture and tradition.

Kani, a man who helped Vilie to attain the heart stone and his spiritual-world wife Subale from border village sets an example for the real Nagas because they both stick on to the traditional method of life which encompasses the spiritual world and the enigmatic landscapes. The border village having "a small settlement of determined people who have made their dwellings in an impossible place" (88). Kani and Subale are the representatives of the ancient

Nagaland which consist of folklore and myths, they set an example for acknowledging their tradition and culture. Kani, shares his wisdom about the supernatural world.

Mesanuo, she is an epitome of faith, wisdom, love and hope. She has uncouned the dark side of the humanity with the help of supernatural faith and defend the evil spirit that concede the righteousness of the human soul. Though she was isolated from the village, Mesanuo did not leave the village. She did not worry about the other people because spiritual strength in her helped Mesanuo to impregnate with the rain drop. Hence the dependency on the spiritual world is recomposed by the supernatural elements, as Mesanuo's faith was rewarded by her son Rhalie. The supernatural mystic world consists of both good and evil spirits and an evil spirit can be controlled by a man of complete integrity.

Universal wisdom of love, hope and forgiveness are amalgamated with the life of Naga in Kire's novels. Mesanuo forgives the villagers who blamed her for the death of her husband and her son. Mesanuo, before leaving the village to visit her sisters leaves a sack of grain outside her house and she says to Pele, that through the act of kindness and hospitality these grains can be used by their guests, if somebody visits their home in their absence. Naga culture is divulged through the action of Mesanuo who believes in the virtue of helping the people in need. Thus through the character of Mesanuo author reveals the foundation of Naga culture is the universal wisdom of compassion.

The innate goodness of the human beings can be revealed with the wisdom of life and Kire reveals it through her novels affinity for the fellow beings and other living creatures. It emanates from the consciousness of spiritual power - vilie, during his journey to sleeping river, he was blamed for a murder which he did not commit. Though he did not commit any mistake he was feeling very bad till the end of his journey. Thus wisdom of compassion is intertwined in Naga culture.

In *Son of the Thundercloud*, Kire gives a fusion of the supernatural and the universal wisdom of life. Rhalie and Siedze had a beautiful relationship, she cared Rhalie as her own son and they both cared for each other. Rhalie admires the innate beauty and he did not worry about the physical appearance of the Spidery hands rather he enjoys the warmth of her hands. Hence Rhalie with supernatural provenance unveils the transcendental power of compassion and love which will last till the death and even beyond the death. Kethonuo once said to Rhalie about the power of true love, that truth will persist even over materialize worldly death. The supernatural and universal wisdom is evident through the words of Mesanuo after the death of Rhalie. She says that the hatred of villagers for Rhalie has made them hurting their own self (Pongen 297). The supernatural world has showered abundant prosperity and fertility but still the mankind falls to the darker side of humanity and famine would return again. Mesanuo says to Pele, "Life is hard and unexpected, but we can direct it to go the way we want it to. It is up to us" (92). These lines make us clear that Mesanuo's character also modifies the wisdom of life. The spiritual world powers Nagas to take up the life in a proper way. The folklore and other oral narratives are not merely a fanciful stories but an educational medium to impart some

cherished tenets to the community at large with the combination of the divine and universal wisdom. The stories helped the people to come out of their darker side and help them to lead a proper life.

Conviction of were-tiger is another supernatural facet of Naga culture. According to Michael Heneise, spirit -tiger or tekhumiaivi has the concept of theriomorphism as its core. The soul transfers between human and tiger results in weretiger. Rhalie was born to kill weretiger in the novel *Son of the Thundercloud*, to protect the people from evil. The protagonist Vilie and Rhalie killed the weretigers with the help of the spiritual powers and goodness of heart. Thus Naga culture is composed with supernatural elements.

The novels of Kire, *Son of the Thundercloud* and *When the River Sleeps* disclose the Naga culture and sovereignty, which is at stake due to constant inroads of modernization and globalization trends in modern era. Naga culture vanishes out of the society due to the spread of Christianity and western education. These novels bring out the divinity in the Naga culture along with the supernatural and natural world.

In both the novels, the evil spirits and the dark ones are destroyed with the help of story tellers and they are overpowered by the spiritual wisdom and credence to the folklore that helps to keep up their spirits and hope. This incidents give us the various factors that lead to the cultural loss in Nagaland and how they strive to preserve Naga culture and tradition.

Nagaland's beauty is not in mountains, clouds and climate but its real beauty lies in their culture, belief, tradition and mystical elements of the Nagaland. Easterine from her novels portrays that the people of Nagaland are trained by their ancestors, such as believing the supernatural elements and mystical stories because these ideas would help them to lead a better life. Her novels bring out that the innate human world is a blend of universal hope, universal wisdom and identity. These novels play an important role in disclosing Naga culture for a global recognition and understanding. It is said by Paul Pimomo, "Easterine Kire is the keeper of her people's memory, their griot. She is the master of the unadorned language that moves because of the power of its evocative simplicity" (qtd.in. "Bitter Wormwood").

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